THE LETTERS OF THE RAMBAM

Say It, Then Leave: The Rambam's Answer

Letter on Martyrdom, Part 4

Source: Igrot HaRambam: *Iggeret HaShmad* / *Ma'amar Kiddush Hashem*, conclusion (Sections 4–5)

Shiur: Eighth class in the series on the Rambam's letters, given by Dayan Daniel Kada on Zoom, Tuesday 18 March 2025 (first part of the evening, before the letter to Rav Pinchas HaDayan)

These notes are based on the Sofer.ai transcript of the recording.

Recap

The question: may a Jew **acknowledge Muhammad** to the one coercing him, to save his life? Another rabbi said those who did were wicked deniers of God; the Rambam demolished that, then answered in five parts:

§	Content
1	**When must one die?** Three cardinal sins: always. Other sins: if the coercer wants his own benefit, never; if he wants to make the Jew sin, **during *shmad*, always** (even one-on-one), otherwise **only before ten Jews**
2	**Chillul Hashem** (two kinds for everyone, two for leaders) and **kiddush Hashem**, with their punishment and reward
3	One **killed** for Hashem: an incomparable reward. One who **should have died and didn't**: wrong, but **no punishment in this world**

By Section 1, it would seem that during *shmad* one must die rather than acknowledge Muhammad, even privately. **Section 4** explains why not.

Section 4: Why This Persecution Is Different

Every persecution in the Sages' time was about an *action*, doing or not doing: *don't learn Torah, don't circumcise, have forbidden relations.* **This one asks us only to *say* something.** You can keep the whole Torah in private; nobody requires you to break Shabbat. They want only that we acknowledge their prophet, **and they know perfectly well that those who say it don't mean it.**

The ruling

One who gives his life rather than acknowledge Muhammad has done well: he has sanctified Hashem's name, and his reward is great.

But if he asks me "should I die or acknowledge?", I say: acknowledge, and live.

But don't linger. Don't walk about the streets where they'll ask you again. Stay home; if you must do business, do it quietly. Keep a low profile so you're not tested again.

When the Sages said "die rather than transgress," **they never meant speech**, only doing what is forbidden or not doing what is commanded. We've **never** encountered a persecution like this, demanding only words.

Keep every mitzvah you still can

You must still try to **keep all the mitzvot**. Don't say "I've already done something forbidden, so..." If you were forced to **break Shabbat**, don't then think you may **carry** too.

Yeravam ben Nevat, who led all Israel to idolatry, will be punished in the World to Come **for the golden calves, and for not making *eruv tavshilin***: the Sages' standard example of the most minor mitzvah. (Avraham, by contrast, kept the whole Torah, **"even eruv tavshilin"**.)

Two sins at once: if someone **steals** his friend's wine and pours it as a **libation to an idol**, he's executed and doesn't repay the wine: **קים ליה בדרבה מיניה**, the greater penalty absorbs the lesser. **That's only in this world.** In the next, he answers for **both**.

"We often have this tendency to see things black and white: *I'm not so observant with this, fine.* No. **Every detail is taken into account.** Not like the other rabbi, who said if you acknowledged Muhammad there's no point going to shul any more."

Leave, even without your family

My advice to all: **go to a place where you can practise freely**, without being made to acknowledge a false prophet, **even if it means leaving family and property**. The wise know that family, spouse, children and possessions are beautiful, **but none of it is eternal** the way doing Hashem's will is.

As the Rambam himself did.

- **Choose the better place.** Even between two **Jewish** cities, live in the more observant. A person should live only where there are **ten righteous people**: Hashem told Avraham He'd spare **Sedom for ten**.
- **Environment shapes you.** David: **כי גרשוני היום מהסתפח בנחלת ה' לאמר לך עבוד אלהים אחרים**: "they drove me from Hashem's heritage, saying *go serve other gods*." The Gemara: **living outside the Land among idolaters is like serving idols. הלא משנאיך ה' אשנא**: "I hate those who hate You."
- **Avraham** left his birthplace and family, **Ur Kasdim**.

Advice, or obligation?

Situation	Leaving is
Only acknowledging the prophet (this *shmad*)	**Advice**: get out as soon as you can
Being forced to actually transgress	**Obligatory**: **"go now. Travel night and day"** until you find a place to practise freely. **The world is big**

a man cannot redeem his brother" (Tehillim 49). **Don't use family as an** ":**אח לא פדה יפדה איש excuse**: "my children are too young to travel at night in the mountains." "When you care about something, you travel even at the hardest times, even with little children." If you could have left .and didn't, **coercion becomes almost your own fault**

"But Mashiach is coming"

Those who say **"we'll wait here, Mashiach is coming any day"** are wrong. **There's no fixed time.**

The Rambam is forceful about this elsewhere too: he opposes anyone who says Mashiach is coming today, tomorrow, or in ten years. **Our duty is to keep the Torah**, and if we merit Mashiach, wonderful. **"When Mashiach comes, life continues as usual"**; the main difference is sovereignty. It's no excuse to stay somewhere you'll have to give up your religion.

The Mishneh Torah is harsher

Codifying this later in the **Mishneh Torah** (Yesodei HaTorah, Chapter 5), the Rambam is **more forceful**: one who is coerced but **could have fled and didn't**, "I've got my nice house here, my friends, my family," and is then told "bow to Jesus or die" and complies:

he is **like a dog returning to its vomit**, considered a :**הרי הוא ככלב שב על קיאו .deliberate** idolater, and loses his share in the World to Come

Perhaps the young Rambam of the letter was **giving hope and consolation**; codifying, he took the harder line. **Shulchan Aruch, Yoreh De'ah 157** follows it: failing to die when required is wrong but carries no known consequence, **unless you could have left and chose to stay.**

Section 5: If You Stay Anyway

If you **can** leave and don't, you're doing wrong, **close to desecrating Hashem's name**, and will be punished.

And yet every mitzvah you do there is enormously valuable, with extra reward, because you do it where you're **persecuted** for doing it.

"Again the Rambam doesn't take a black-or-white approach." But don't **stay in order** to earn more reward; keep thinking how to get out.

Don't push them away

Even those **regularly desecrating Shabbat** there: **don't reject them**. Draw them to the mitzvot; **receive them warmly**.

don't despise the thief when he steals" (Mishlei). The Sages: when sinners" :**לא יבוזו לגנב כי יגנוב** come to **"steal" a mitzvah**, coming to shul to pray or do something good, **don't embarrass .them; bring them close**

The close

Since our exile we've never been free of persecution. **We grow up in pain from birth.** We know persecutions end. May this one pass, and may Yirmeyahu's words be fulfilled: Israel's sins will be sought and **not found**.

"How appropriate to end the letter on that note. We've always been through difficult times, and we are going through difficult times. But we know we will be victorious."

A Question to Think About

The Rambam says one who **died** rather than acknowledge Muhammad **did well** and sanctified Hashem's name. But elsewhere he holds that **one who dies when not required to has done wrong**. Here he rules you **need not** die, so how is dying praiseworthy? "There seems to be a grey area. There is a technical answer," for those who stay after the recording.

Summary of the Whole Letter

1. **First half:** the Rambam castigates a rabbi who wrote that anyone acknowledging Muhammad forfeited everything, and that there's no point in mitzvot any more.
2. **Section 1:** when one must give one's life.
3. **Section 2:** chillul Hashem and kiddush Hashem.
4. **Section 3:** the martyr's exalted reward; one who gave in did wrong, but life goes on.
5. **Section 4: this persecution demands only words**, so **acknowledge rather than die**, keep every mitzvah you can, and **leave**. If forced to **sin**, leaving is **obligatory**; family and "Mashiach is coming" are no excuse. The Mishneh Torah later makes staying when one could leave far graver.
6. **Section 5:** staying is wrong, but every mitzvah done under persecution is precious, and those who sin there must be **embraced, not rejected**.

Coming Up

Next, the same evening: the Rambam's **letter to Rav Pinchas HaDayan** of Alexandria, "a very halachic letter," and the first between the Rambam and **a colleague**.

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